

trivialising Akbar, they have made him a cartoon hero, fit for consumption in our short attention span times. In the popular imagination, Akbar is seen either as the stern and decidedly unromantic father of the Devdas-like Prince Salim who pines for Anarkali in *Mughal-e-Azam* or the dunce-like figure of Akbar and Birbal comics. Gowariker's Akbar is a warrior lover, born of Indian soil, a New Age man who gives his woman her space (and the freedom to worship her god) and knows a thing or two about taming wild elephants. This is a younger Akbar, between 13 and 38, not paunchy but raunchy. "All I wanted was to show the poignant moments between him and Jodha Bai," says Gowariker. He has done that in heaps and bounds. Akbar is every chick flick watcher's dishy dreamboat and Jodha, at once tremulous and tremendous, every romantic fiction reader's version of herself or Elizabeth Bennett.

This is also an Akbar who is being made more palatable to a Hindu majority, his bloody siege of Chittor in 1568 forgotten—and what some historians have called a return to Islamic orthodoxy between 1567 and 1579, which then changed to a policy of tolerance from 1579 onwards. The Mughals, as Raja Todar Mal tells the denizens of the Agra Bazaar in another thoroughly creative scene in *Jodhaa Akbar*, were neither *videshi* (foreign) nor *lootere* (looters). It is a debate settled long ago except in textbooks sponsored by the RSS. Gowariker's *Jodhaa Akbar* are shown running the empire like a Hillary and Bill Clinton team, which may be a thoroughly modern idea but has no resemblance to facts. As film scholar Suresh Chhabria put it: "Like earlier Mughal romances, *Jodhaa Akbar* is the stuff of legend and not history. A political and strategic military alliance is romanticised; and a Hindu-Muslim marriage is the stuff of nation-building projects. Abul Fazl and other chroniclers of the period are silent on the

"It's an injustice to Akbar to say that one princess could change the course of history."

SHIREEN MOOSVI, HISTORIAN



SET MAX: The film is Bollywood's costume central, where care has been lavished on crafting the props intimate details. And this silence is filled by storytellers."

This is not the first time Bollywood has played fast and loose with history. In *The Rising*, Mangal Pandey, an accidental hero, was mythologised, while the English were romanticised through the fictional character of British officer William Gordon. Though Pandey did fire the first shots of Independence, none of them killed—or even injured—an Englishman. Even Kamal Amrohi's *Razia Sultana* (1983) was a highly rose-tinted version of

Itutmish's successor who had an affair with her Assyrian slave, Yakut. Hollywood's historical accuracy of *Braveheart* and *The Patriot* routinely gets labelled as garbage. But is *Jodhaa Akbar*'s heavy onscreen petting likely to pose such a threat to Rajput civilisation as we know it? Not quite. After all, twopenny guides regularly point out Jodha Bai's temple at Fatehpur Sikri—and it has not threatened the Rajput martial legacy so far. *Jodhaa Akbar*, which may well have been called *Heer Ranjha* or indeed *Romeo Juliet*, is a movie that celebrates opulence to suit the new luxe loving Indian, with gem-encrusted jewellery and brocade bordered costumes. Will it make Akbar the new pin-up of the new Indian woman? A *Mills and Boon* hero straight from the Middle Ages? If it does, it will not be accurate but it will be the triumph of Gowariker and Ali's fantasy.

with Rohit Parihar

"Like earlier Mughal romances, *Jodhaa Akbar* is the stuff of legend, not history."

SURESH CHHABRIA, FILM SCHOLAR